

3.1 Shakespeare: language and performance

Paper 3 Shakespeare and Drama · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Interpret Shakespearean speech through situation, verse/prose, imagery, rhetorical pattern and relationships on stage. A soliloquy makes the audience privy to thought; an aside may separate speaker and characters. Quote accurately from the prescribed edition and discuss how different performances could alter tone.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A repeated question can sound searching or accusatory depending on pause and address; a comparison of performances should connect both readings to words on the page.

Original practice stimulus

KING: My crown is lighter when the room is dark. ADVISER: Then let the lamps be put away. KING: I did not ask for darkness. (He lifts the crown, then sets it beside the chair.) ADVISER: You asked me here at midnight. KING: In daylight they hear the gold before they hear my words. (Footsteps sound beyond the door.) ADVISER: The council waits. KING: How many? ADVISER: Enough to call it a council. (A pause. The KING leaves the crown on the chair and opens the door.) The lines and stage directions in this exercise are original and do not come from a Shakespeare play.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original invented line for practice: "My crown is lighter when the room is dark."

[25]

Discuss possible meanings and ways an actor might voice it; then apply the method to a set Shakespeare passage.

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong response explores crown as political burden, darkness as secrecy or rest, and actor choices of emphasis/pause. It is a technique exercise; the original line is not a quotation from Shakespeare or a prescribed play.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

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<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

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